INDIA@PARIS 2024

CHASING A HIGHER GOAL

MEN'S TEAM

Sport: ***HOCKEY***

Achievement: **Bronze at Tokyo 2020 Games**

How they qualified: **Won the gold medal at the 2022 Asian Games**

On August 5, 2021, a nation rejoiced and heaved a sigh of relief. The 41-year wait for an Olympic medal in hockey was finally over. Generations had grown up hearing of the heroics and dominance of India—the historic eight Olympic gold medals won, a record still unbroken. "Until Tokyo, we heard about the victories but, in the present, we were nowhere on top... we never saw a medal in hand," says goalkeeper P.R. Sreejesh, 36. That morning in Tokyo changed it all. "We saw the love and respect hockey got," notes Harmanpreet Singh, 28, the current captain and part of the bronze-winning team. Eleven members of that squad are headed to Paris and they don't intend to return empty-handed. Says Sreejesh, "Once you taste success, you know what to do to make it happen again and achieve the target." Adds Harmanpreet, "There is pressure to do well and come back with a medal. You want to do better. You have to keep achieving."

What the Tokyo Games did was



Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH

PUSH FOR PARIS
Members of the Indian Hockey Team at the Sports Authority of India's facility in Bengaluru